

THE MARGIN-PROOF TRACKER

Eleven companies say AI is paying off. None can prove it.

Every public AI-value claim we track, scored on one evidence ladder. Nobody has reached the top rung.



Swipe: where each of the eleven actually sits,
and what it would take to move a row.

THE EVIDENCE LADDER

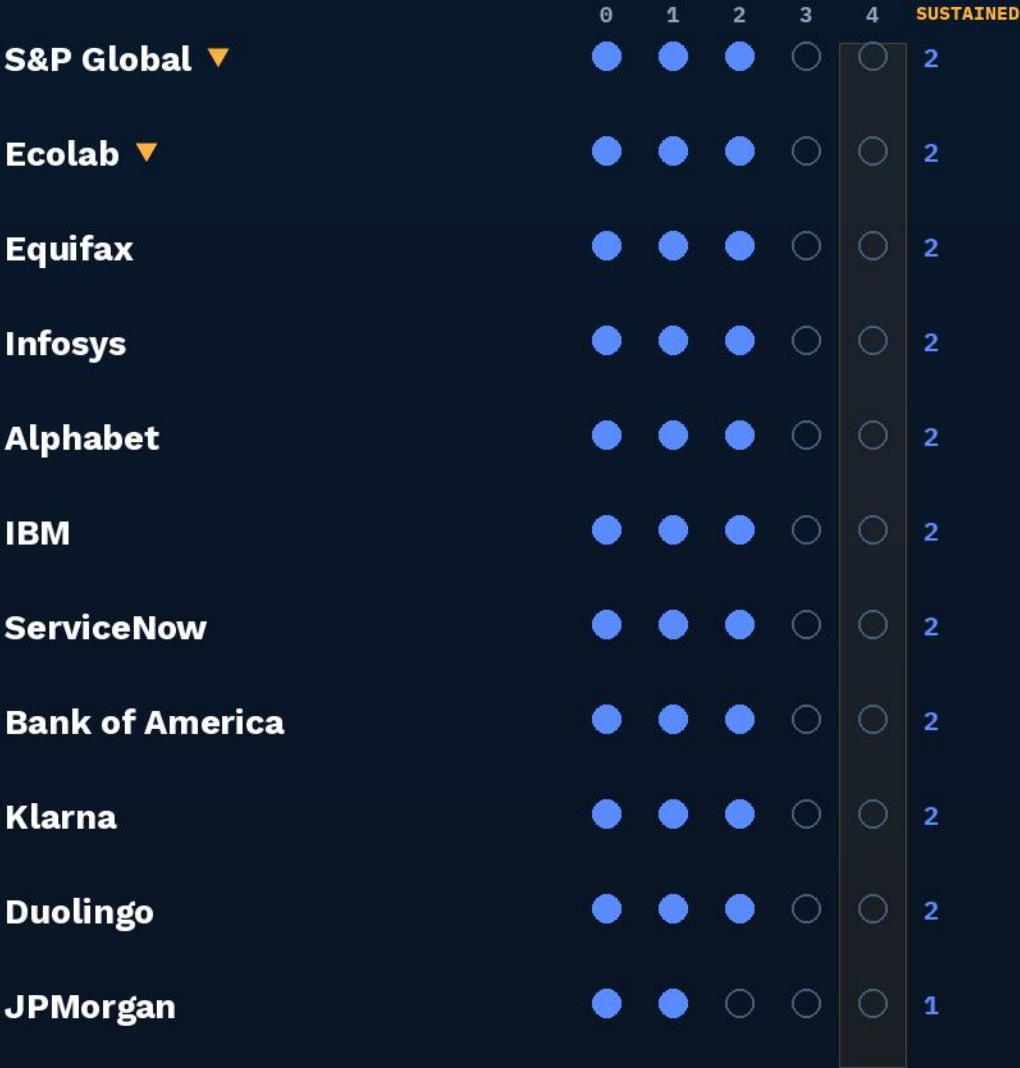
Five rungs. Only the top one counts.

- 0 Narrative**
A story about AI. No number attached.
- 1 Operational**
A quantified activity number. Seats, tickets, hours.
- 2 Financial claim**
A dollar figure asserted. Nothing reconciled.
- 3 P&L-attributed**
AI isolated in reported results.
- 4 Sustained**
Stage 3 holds four straight quarters.

Nobody we track is above rung 2.

THE SCOREBOARD · JUL 2026

Where the eleven actually sit

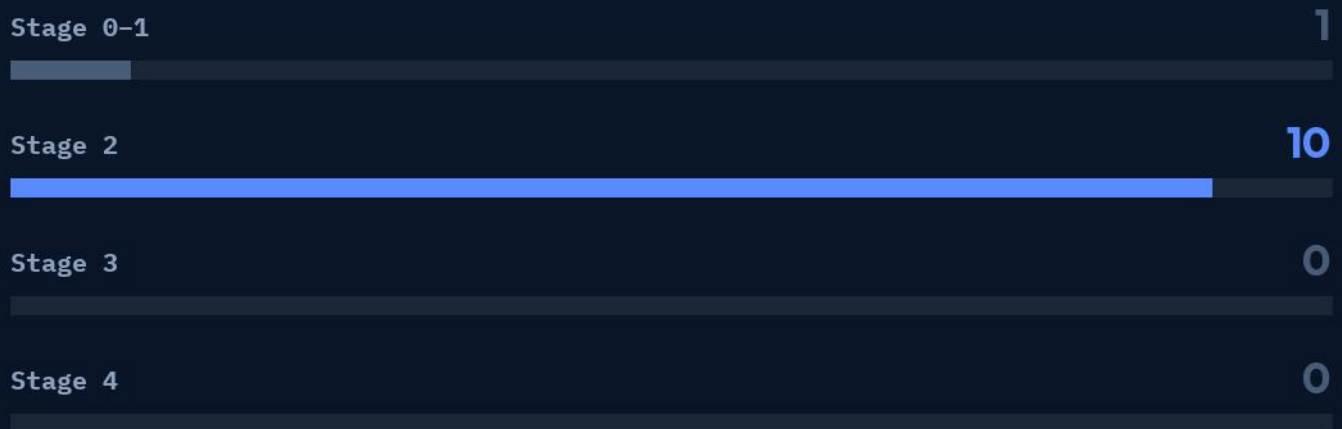


▼ marked down this issue. Stage 4 column: empty.

THE SHAPE OF IT

Ten of eleven sit on the same rung.

Stage 2 is where a company has asserted a dollar figure and never reconciled it to reported results. It is the most comfortable place on the ladder: it sounds like proof and commits to nothing.



WHAT STAGE 2 ACTUALLY MEANS

A claim asserted. Never reconciled.

IBM

Gen-AI is about half of Consulting signings.

Signings are not revenue. Guidance was cut the same quarter.

ServiceNow

AI crossed \$1B in annual contract value.

Contracted, not booked. The \$1.5B target was held, not raised.

Equifax

AI cost target doubled to \$150M.

It sized the saving and put no number on the upside.

THIS ISSUE'S CORRECTION

We marked two rows down.

Issue 005 graded S&P Global and Ecolab at Stage 3. Both are Stage 2.

Stage 3 requires AI isolated in reported results. Neither company has made that attribution in its own filings — the claim traces to a bank's review of earnings calls. That is third-party attribution, not own-filing evidence.

S&P Global ~~STAGE 3~~ ▼ **STAGE 2**

Ecolab ~~STAGE 3~~ ▼ **STAGE 2**

They report Tuesday. Their own numbers can earn the row back.

WHY THE TOP RUNG IS EMPTY

Four straight quarters is the bar.

Stage 4 asks for one thing: an AI-attributed margin gain that holds for a year. Not a target. Not a pilot. A number in reported results, four times running.

Nothing in the disclosure regime requires a company to produce that. AI costs land in audited lines because accounting rules put them there. AI revenue lands in signings, backlog and contract value — none of which touch an audited statement.

So the absence is not shyness.

It is what the reporting rules currently permit.

RUN THIS ON YOUR OWN AI SPEND

Four questions.

01 Can a rival buy it tomorrow?

Then budget it as table stakes and negotiate it like a utility.

02 Does it run on something only you have?

Proprietary data, a licence, a physical asset, a regulatory position.

03 Is it tied to your operations specifically?

Or would it work identically at a competitor?

04 Will it still be scarce in three years?

Scarcity is the whole of the advantage.

Mostly "anyone can buy it" → you are funding a cost line.

Mostly "only us" → that is where advantage forms.

WHAT MOVES A ROW NEXT

The next three tests

TUE JUL 28

S&P Global · Ecolab

Both report. Either earns Stage 3 or the claim comes off the board.

WED AUG 5

Duolingo

Q2. Is the per-unit AI cost drop visible in margin?

TUE AUG 18

Klarna

Q2. Does the vendor's own math survive a filing?

**We publish the ladder
every Sunday.**

Free. aiabovethecut.com